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The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, occasional rain, early snow and sleet, high 40. **Tonight**, mostly cloudy, rain at times, low 36. **Tomorrow**, mostly cloudy, not as chilly, high 51. Weather map, Page B12.

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Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00

TRUMP FORESEES EXTENDED ATTACK ON IRAN AS U.S. ADDS TROOPS AND JETS TO THE REGION

Pressed by Israel, U.S. Prepared for Strikes

This article is by Mark Mazzetti, Julian E. Barnes, Tyler Pager, Edward Wong, Eric Schmitt and Ronen Bergman.

WASHINGTON — Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of Israel walked into the Oval Office on the morning of Feb. 11, determined to keep the American president on the path to war.

For weeks, the United States and Israel had been secretly discussing a military offensive against Iran. But Trump administration officials had recently begun negotiating with the Iranians over the future of their nuclear program, and the Israeli leader wanted to make sure that the new diplomatic effort did not undermine the plans.

Over nearly three hours, the two leaders discussed the prospects of war and even possible dates for an attack, as well as the possibility — however unlikely — that President Trump might reach a deal with Iran.

Days later, the president made clear publicly that he was skeptical of the diplomatic route, dismissing the history of negotiating with Iran as merely years of “talking and talking and talking.”

Asked by reporters if he wanted regime change in Iran, Mr. Trump said it “seems like that would be the best thing that could happen.”

Two weeks later, the president took the United States to war. He authorized a vast military bombardment in conjunction with Israel that swiftly killed the country’s supreme leader, pummeled Iranian civilian buildings and military nuclear sites, thrust the country into chaos and set off violence across the region, leading to the deaths so far of six U.S. troops and scores of Iranian civilians. Mr. Trump has said more American casualties are likely as the United States digs in for an assault that could last weeks.

In public, Mr. Trump appeared to take a circuitous path to military action, alternating between saying that he wanted to make a deal with Iran’s government and that he wanted to topple it. He made little effort to try to convince the American public that a war was necessary now. And the limited case he and his aides made included false claims about the imminence of the threat that Iran posed to the United States.

But behind the scenes, his move toward war grew inexorably, fueled by allies like Mr. Netanyahu who pushed the president to strike a decisive blow against Iran’s theocratic government, and by Mr. Trump’s own confidence after the successful U.S. operation that toppled the Venezuelan leader Nicolás Maduro in January.

This reconstruction of Mr. Trump’s decision to launch a sustained attack against Iran is based on the accounts of people with direct knowledge of the deliberations, as well as those on all sides of the debate, including diplomats from the region, Israeli and American administration officials, the president’s advisers, congressional lawmakers and defense and intelligence officials. Almost all spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe sensitive discussions and operational details.

The U.S. decision to strike Iran was a victory for Mr. Netanyahu, who had been pushing Mr. Trump

Continued on Page A6



ARASH KHAMOOSHI FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

IRAN The Gandhi Hospital in Tehran on Monday. The World Health Organization’s director general expressed concern and reiterated that health facilities were protected under international law.



DIEGO IBARRA SANCHEZ FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

LEBANON Forced to flee their homes after Israeli strikes, people waited to enter the Hotel Technical School in West Beirut. Israel was responding to rockets fired by the Iran-allied militia Hezbollah.



AVISHAG SHAAR-YASHUV FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

ISRAEL Seeking shelter in Rishpon after sirens warned of missiles from Iran. As U.S. and Israeli planes pounded targets in Iran for a third day, President Trump said bigger airstrikes were coming.

Qatar Reports Tehran’s Planes in Foreign Skies as War Spreads

This article is by Shawn McCreesh, Tyler Pager, Eric Schmitt, Helene Cooper and Abdi Latif Dahir.

WASHINGTON — President Trump said on Monday that the United States would continue attacking Iran for as long as it took to leave it incapable of posing a threat, an indication that an expanding war in the Middle East could continue for weeks or more.

“Whatever the time is, it’s OK, whatever it takes,” Mr. Trump said at an event at the White House, in his first public comments on the war since U.S.-Israeli airstrikes on Iran began on Saturday. “Right from the beginning we projected four to five weeks, but we have the capability to go far longer than that,” he added. “We’ll do it.”

The Trump administration has at times offered conflicting rationales and expectations for the campaign. While Mr. Trump signaled that the United States was prepared for a long war and had urged the Iranian people to rise up against the government, the American defense secretary, Pete Hegseth, vowed that the operation would not become another protracted Middle Eastern conflict.

“This is not Iraq,” Mr. Hegseth said at a Pentagon news conference on Monday. “This is not endless.”

Gen. Dan Caine, the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, said at the same news conference that the campaign was in its early stages, with more American forces heading to the Middle East.

“This work is just beginning and will continue,” General Caine said, adding that when additional fighter jets arrived in the coming days, the United States would be “just about where we want to be in terms of total combat capacity and total combat power.”

Mr. Trump, in separate news interviews, declined to rule out sending ground troops into Iran and said that still-bigger waves of airstrikes were coming.

Listing his objectives, he said, “We’re destroying Iran’s missile capability, and we’re doing that

hourly.” He added that the strikes were “annihilating their navy,” ensuring that Iran “can never obtain a nuclear weapon” and that it cannot continue to sponsor militant groups across the Middle East.

Internationally, he claimed, “everybody was behind us; they just didn’t have the courage to say so.” Mr. Trump concluded his remarks at a Medal of Honor ceremony in Washington without taking questions from reporters.

In a sign of the widening conflict, Qatar’s Ministry of Defense said its air force had shot down two Su-24 bombers coming from Iran, the first report that Iran — which has fired missiles and drones at its neighbors in the Persian Gulf and in retaliation for the U.S.-Israeli assault — had also sent warplanes into foreign airspace.

Continued on Page A9



DOUG MILLS/THE NEW YORK TIMES

The president said the U.S. was prepared to spend five weeks or longer to achieve its goals.

LESSONS LOST Despite warnings after an earlier wave of killings, top Iranian officials gathered at their last known address. PAGE A7

DOUBT ON DIPLOMACY The U.S. again struck against a country in talks. News Analysis. PAGE A9

RIISING ANXIETY Many in Cuba wonder if the United States will attack their country next. PAGE A11

NEWS ANALYSIS

Conflict Sets Up Shift in Iran Of Hazy Direction and Degree

By ERIKA SOLOMON

The death of Iran’s supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, is a watershed moment in the 47-year existence of the Islamic Republic. The scenes that followed — throngs of Iranians taking to the streets to celebrate, others turning out to grieve — signal the deep uncertainty about what comes next.

There are now three key questions: How will Iranians respond to President Trump’s call to take over the government? Can Iran’s authoritarian system survive? And could the attack unleash a chaotic power struggle?

Mr. Trump and Israel’s prime minister, Benjamin Netanyahu, have made public appeals to Iran’s people, arguing that they have offered them a historic opportunity to topple their brutal

authoritarian government. How they envision an unarmed population facing down a heavily armed, ideologically driven security force is less clear.

Though it has been only three days of strikes, some regional experts are skeptical that an aerial campaign alone could weaken Iran’s government enough that Iranians could bring it down with protests.

Nonetheless, Iran is headed toward a transformative moment, said Farzan Sabet, an analyst on Iran and Middle East politics at the Geneva Graduate Institute in Switzerland.

“Some kind of change will happen in the system,” he said. “But in which direction? We don’t know.”

Continued on Page A8

Kennedy’s Anti-Vaccine Disciples See ‘Betrayal’

By BENJAMIN MUELLER

To all appearances, it was the next stage in the dismantling of the American vaccine program. Federal regulators refused last month to review a new mRNA flu shot from Moderna, the latest consequence of Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.’s campaign to give skeptics control of the bureaucracy overseeing inoculations.

But then, curiously, regulators had a change of heart. Within weeks, the review of the mRNA

Crisis of Faith Follows Pivot to Much Safer Political Ground

shot was back on.

The reversal strengthened a belief that has gained traction lately among Mr. Kennedy’s most zealous anti-vaccine followers. In their view, the health secretary has erred not by taking a sledgehammer to the country’s vaccine

apparatus, but rather by leaving too much of the edifice standing.

On Mr. Kennedy’s watch, millions of children in recent months still received Covid shots, “the deadliest vaccine ever made,” as he has falsely described it. The manufacturers remain protected from liability claims, despite Mr. Kennedy’s blaming that system three years ago for enabling “mass murder.”

Influential vaccine skeptics are starting to depart even from the Centers for Disease Control and

Continued on Page A19

In Texas, Test of What Voters Want in Midterms

By LISA LERER and J. DAVID GOODMAN

DALLAS — As the midterm elections that will decide who controls Congress get fully underway this week with the first primary contests, both parties are grappling with one of the central questions of American politics in the Trump era: Do voters want partisan rage or a political reset?

Amid one of the most volatile political moments in decades, Democrats are trying to figure out whether their path back to power

Senate Primaries Each Offer Stark Contrast in Approaches

is to re-energize their base with fiery appeals or to court swing voters. Republicans are testing the continuing power of the MAGA brand over traditional conservatism.

Those dynamics are being tested in Texas, where voters

head to the polls on Tuesday to cast their ballots in primaries for the U.S. Senate that have already broken records for early voting turnout and political spending.

Senator John Cornyn, a four-term senator once seen as the courtly, conservative embodiment of the Texas Republican brand, is fighting for his political life against Ken Paxton, the state’s scandal-scarred attorney general who is beloved by the MAGA base.

On the Democratic side, James Talarico, a state representative,

Continued on Page A16

NATIONAL A12-19

Losing Access to H.I.V. Drugs

Citing rising costs and shortfalls in federal aid, nearly 20 states are toughening eligibility requirements for patients in treatment programs. PAGE A14

BUSINESS B1-6

The World’s Back Office

Artificial intelligence promises to automate the white-collar work that made India a tech force. The country is racing to adapt before it’s too late. PAGE B1

SPORTS B7-10, 12

Defeating the Darkness

Dejounte Murray has overcome an Achilles’ tendon injury and several personal setbacks to revive his N.B.A. career in New Orleans. PAGE B7

ARTS C1-6

A Star’s Difficult Journey

Christina Applegate’s memoir finds the “Married ... With Children” actress facing childhood trauma and reflecting on the limits imposed by illness. PAGE C1

OPINION A20-21

Thomas L. Friedman

PAGE A20

